

Microsoft Internet Explorer and Netscape Navigator. Both had their own little ways of handling the front-end, and so websites were usually IE-ready or Navigator-ready. (Do you remember those disclaimers: “Best viewed in <browser> at a resolution of <resolution>”? If not, then please visit any Indian government website to refresh your memory, or press **Ctrl+R** for a hard refresh of your memory.)

In time, Navigator gave way to Firefox and Opera, and then Safari, Chrome and multitudes of other browsers that joined the party. As the number of browsers, and their treatment of the front-end started varying, the developer's life became miserable with trying to ensure ‘cross-browser compatibility’. [Read more on cross-browser compatibility at Wikipedia - <http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cross-browser>]

The World Wide Web Consortium (W3C) became their champion, when it started formulating standards to ease development hell by making the technology standard. What followed was ECMAScript, DOM, XHTML, XML, and many such standards. These did not entirely remove the need for cross-browser compatibility efforts, but did help minimise it.

Needless to say, even browser developers realised how such standardisation would help their end users, and thus have an impact on their market shares. They rushed to be more standards-compliant. The race was led by Opera and Firefox. When Google released Chrome, it added new paradigms to user experience, by not only adhering to standards but experimenting with and augmenting how people use the Web. There was only one problem: Microsoft browsers were a little stubborn when it came to following standards. It was also a considerable problem, since Microsoft always had the major market share for browsers. With Internet Explorer 9 entering the scene in March this year, a major leap has been made—finally all browsers follow the same set of standards, and thus increase cross-browser compatibility (see what Microsoft has to say about IE6 at the following link: [The Internet Explorer 6 Countdown - http://www.ie6countdown.com/](http://www.ie6countdown.com/)).

With the evolution of these standards, and the browsers that implemented them, the Internet evolved to something more powerful and more social than it ever was. This paved the way to a new set of principles that address how the Internet should grow further. Say hello to the Open Web.

The past is closed. The future is open

As we just saw, the evolution of the Internet was not simple. It started from the dark ages of tools doing as they wished over the Internet, but moved towards a transparent and accessible Web. The drive to make it yet more open, transparent and accessible,

needed a name—and that was the Open Web (Refer to “What is the Open Web and Why it matters?” at <http://codinginparadise.org/weblog/2008/04/whats-open-web-and-why-is-it-important.html>). Mozilla, amongst other browsers, is a champion of the cause, striving towards building an open Web. Opera, Firefox and Chrome are the major front runners of the initiative. The Open Web Foundation governs and defines the Open Web principles, and furthers its cause.

The Open Web strives to create a Web where there are no technology lock-ins: an Internet open to all participants and all innovations on the platform. It will be transparent, decentralised and accessible. All modern browsers further the Open Web cause by their adherence to open standards and open formats, and by their commitment to abstract the technological challenges required to interact with the Web.

Half the battle has been won

We started this article with hopes of understanding what makes Firefox a very special browser. We know that like all modern browsers, Firefox adheres to open standards, has a commitment to the Open Web, and strives to make the Web a better place. So what makes Firefox such a sweetheart? A number of factors actually.

Mozilla Firefox arose from the ashes of Netscape Navigator, and has been the first major browser to challenge Microsoft Internet Explorer (after Navigator, that is) and the closed Web. Since then, Firefox has always been committed to *taking back the Web, one user at a time*.

Firefox is also a completely open source, community-developed browser. Licensed under a tri-licence (MPL, GPL, and LGPL), Firefox has been forked a number of times to create successful derivative browsers like the Ice Weasel.

Since its early days, Firefox has had support for third-party extensions, developed by community members, that add new features to the browser. The Firefox Add-ons are one of the major reasons for the widespread use of the browser, especially in the developer community (we will soon look at some of the most awesome developer add-ons for Firefox, and how they can make your life easier).

Mozilla has an active community around its tools and technologies and the Open Web, and continues to push the Internet forward with community initiatives and platforms such as Mozilla Drumbeat, Mozilla Labs and the ongoing Mozilla Dev Derby.

Mozilla Drumbeat is a project by Mozilla engaged with taking the Web forward from Web developers to regular users, and making it more open and transparent. It is an initiative to foster innovation powered by Web technologies and the Open Web to solve real problems.

Mozilla Firefox has been an active advocate for the Open Web, emerging Web standards and compliance to